Lesson 50: Commonly Confused Words and Spelling

English Stage 3 (C1) · Unit 5: Argument and Academic Style

Adapted from College ESL Writers: Applied Grammar and Composing Strategies for Success by Barbara Hall and Elizabeth Wallace, Georgia State University - Perimeter College (CC BY-NC-SA): 6.1 Commonly Confused Words; 6.2 Spelling.

In this lesson

You will study words that writers often confuse because they sound, look or mean alike (affect and effect, its and it's, than and then), the main spelling rules, commonly misspelled words and homonyms. A spell checker does not catch a correctly spelled wrong word, so you will practise proofreading paragraphs yourself. Accurate words and spelling build your credibility with professors and other readers.

Learning goals

After this lesson you should be able to:

- Choose correctly between commonly confused words such as affect / effect, its / it's and than / then.
- Apply seven common spelling rules for ie / ei, final y, final e and plurals.
- Recognize the problem areas in commonly misspelled words.
- Distinguish common homonyms such as principle / principal and lead / led.
- Proofread a paragraph for word errors that a spell checker misses.

Key language

Word or phrase	Meaning	Example
commonly confused words	words that share a similar pronunciation, meaning or spelling with another word	new / knew
homonym	a word that sounds like another word but has a different meaning (often called a homophone)	peace / piece
contraction	two words joined with an apostrophe that replaces letters	it's = it is; who's = who is or who has
possessive pronoun	a pronoun that shows possession; it never has an apostrophe	its, their, whose, your
vowel / consonant	the letters a, e, i, o, u / the other letters	delay (vowel + y); happy (consonant + y)
ending (suffix)	letters added to the end of a word	-able, -ence, -ing, -ity, -less, -ment, -ly

Word or phrase	Meaning	Example
spell checker	software that flags misspelled words	It will not usually catch "too days" for "two days".
mnemonic device	a memory trick	"be a beautiful person": beautiful begins with "be a"
skim	read quickly without attention to every word	Skimming, you may overlook misspelled words.
credibility	the reader's trust in the writer	Error-free spelling enhances your credibility.

Rules and explanations

Commonly confused words

Words	How to choose	The book's example
a / an / and	**a** before a consonant sound, **an** before a vowel sound; **and** joins words	a key, an ocean, pen and pencil
accept / except	**accept** (verb) = take or agree to something offered; **except** = but, only	They accepted our proposal for the conference.
affect / effect	**affect** (verb) = create a change; **effect** (noun) = a result	Hurricane winds affect the amount of rainfall. The heavy rains will have an effect on the crop growth.
are / our	**are** = a form of "be"; **our** = belonging to us	We will bring our cameras to take pictures.
by / buy	**by** = next to; **buy** = purchase	My glasses are by the bed.
its / it's	**its** = belonging to it; **it's** = it is	The butterfly flapped its wings.
know / no	**know** = understand; **no** = a negative	I have no time to visit the zoo this weekend.
loose / lose	**loose** (adjective) = not tight; **lose** (verb) = misplace, give up, fail to earn	Without a belt, her pants are loose on her waist.
of / have	after could, should, would, must, write **have** (a helping verb), never "of"	I should have helped her with that heavy box.
quite / quiet / quit	**quite** = really; **quiet** = not loud; **quit** = stop	I need a quiet room to complete the assignments.
right / write	**right** = correct, or the opposite of left; **write** = put words on paper	After the team members bowl, I will write down their scores.
set / sit	**set** = put something down (also a group of objects); **sit** = lower yourself onto a seat	She set the mug on the saucer.

Words	How to choose	The book's example
suppose / supposed to	**suppose** = think, or suggest; **be supposed to** = be required or expected to	She was supposed to create the menu.
than / then	**than** compares; **then** = next, or at that time	Doctors first complete medical school and then obtain a residency.
their / they're / there	**their** = belonging to them; **they're** = they are; **there** = in that place, or "there is / are"	There are more treats if the dogs behave.
to / two / too	**to** = toward, or before a verb (to play); **two** = 2; **too** = also, or more than is good	The tents were too loud, and we left.
use / used to	**use** = apply for a purpose; **used to** = a past habit that has stopped	He used to hire a team to landscape, but now he landscapes alone.
who's / whose	**who's** = who is / who has; **whose** = belonging to whom	Whose schedule allows them to take the new student on a campus tour?
your / you're	**your** = belonging to you; **you're** = you are	You're the girl with the unzipped book bag.

(The book defines **too** as "also or very"; more exactly, it means "more than is good or needed": the tents were too loud, so we left.)

Three strategies: use a dictionary (print, online or an app); keep a list of the words you commonly confuse and check it before you submit; study the list before you write. Remember that a spell checker will not usually catch these words, because they are real words.

Spelling rules

Rule	Examples
i before e, except after c, or when it sounds like "ay" (neighbor, weigh)	achieve, niece, alien; receive, deceive
consonant + y: change y to i before an ending (but not before -ing: crying)	happy + er = happier; cry + ed = cried
vowel + y: keep the y	delay + ed = delayed (exceptions: daily, laid, said, paid)
ending that begins with a vowel (-able, -ence, -ing, -ity): drop the final e	write + ing = writing; pure + ity = purity
ending that begins with a consonant (-less, -ment, -ly): keep the final e	hope + less = hopeless; advertise + ment = advertisement
many words ending in consonant + o: add -s	photos, sopranos
words ending in s, ch, sh, x: add -es	churches, faxes

Some rules have exceptions, so check new words in a dictionary.

Commonly misspelled words

The table in your material shows the problem area of each word in bold. Some useful ones for academic writing: arg**u**ment, beha**vi**or, def**ini**te, envir**on**ment, gove**rn**ment, jud**gm**ent, ne**ce**ssary, o**cc**asion, **psy**cholo**gy**, ref**er**ence, sep**ara**te, su**cc**ess, th**orou**gh, wri**tt**en.

Tips: copy each word a few times and underline the problem area; test yourself with flashcards; read your work word by word instead of skimming; use mnemonic devices (say Wed-nes-day to spell Wednesday); keep a list of the words you misspell and add words from your corrected papers; check spelling at the editing stage, after the big ideas and paragraphs.

Commonly misused homonyms

Words	Meanings
principle / principal	a fundamental concept accepted as true / the head of a school, or the original amount of a debt
where / wear / ware(s)	in which place / have on the body (clothes) / goods for sale
lead / led	a metal (it sounds like "led") / the past tense of the verb lead
which / witch	one out of a group / a person who practises sorcery
peace / piece	calm, no conflict / a part of a whole
passed / past	the past tense of pass (went by) / the time before now
lessen / lesson	reduce / something a student studies
patience / patients	the ability to wait or suffer calmly / people under medical care
sees / seas / seize	perceives with the eyes / large bodies of salt water / take by force
threw / through	the past tense of throw / in one side and out of the other

> **In psychology:** "affect" is also a noun meaning feeling or emotion, stressed on the first syllable: "positive affect", "flat affect". In everyday academic writing, the rule above (affect = verb, effect = noun) still holds.
>
> **Note for Arabic speakers** - Arabic writing usually leaves out short vowels, so Arabic speakers often drop or confuse English vowel letters (importent, seperate, opinien). Look hard at the vowels in the problem areas of the misspelled-words table. - Arabic has no /p/ sound, so p and b are easily mixed in spelling (probably, not brobably). Say the word slowly and check it.

Practice

Exercise 1. Commonly confused words. Choose the correct word.

1. My little cousin turns _____ (to, too, two) years old tomorrow.

2. The next-door neighbor's dog is _____ (quite, quiet, quit) loud. He barks constantly throughout the night.
3. _____ (Your, You're) mother called this morning to talk about the party.
4. I would rather eat a slice of chocolate cake _____ (than, then) eat a chocolate muffin.
5. Before the meeting, he drank a cup of coffee, and _____ (than, then) he brushed his teeth.
6. Do you have any _____ (loose, lose) change to pay the parking meter?
7. Father must _____ (have, of) left his briefcase at the office.
8. Before playing ice hockey, I was _____ (suppose, supposed) to read the contract, but I only skimmed it and signed my name quickly, which may _____ (affect, effect) my understanding of the rules.
9. Tonight she will _____ (set, sit) down and _____ (right, write) a cover letter to accompany her résumé and job application.
10. It must be fall, because the leaves _____ (are, our) changing, and _____ (it's, its) getting darker earlier.

Exercise 2. Eleven misused words. In the lesson material, read the paragraph about the Declaration of Independence ("The original United States Declaration of Independence sets in a case..."). Find the eleven misused words and correct them.

Exercise 3. Nine misspelled words. Read the paragraph about Sherman J. Alexie Jr. in the lesson material. Find and correct the nine misspelled words. For each, name the spelling rule that helps, if there is one.

Exercise 4. Ten commonly misspelled words. Read the paragraphs about Brooklyn in the lesson material ("Brooklyn is one of the five boroughs..."). Find and correct the ten misspelled words from the table of commonly misspelled words.

Exercise 5. Homonyms. Choose the correct homonym.

1. Do you agree with the underlying _____ (principle, principal) that ensures copyrights are protected in the digital age?
2. I like to _____ (where, wear, ware) unique clothing from thrift stores that do not have company logos on them.
3. Marjan felt like she was being _____ (led, lead) on a wild goose chase, and she did not like it one bit.
4. Serina described _____ (witch, which) house was hers, but now that I am here, they all look the same.
5. Seeing his friend without a lunch, Miguel gave her a _____ (peace, piece) of his apple.
6. Do you think that it is healthy for mother to talk about the _____ (passed, past) all the time?
7. Eating healthier foods will _____ (lessen, lesson) the risk of heart disease.
8. I know it sounds cliché, but my father had the _____ (patients, patience) of a saint.
9. Daniela _____ (sees, seas, seize) possibilities in the bleakest situations, and that is why she is successful.

10. Everyone goes _____ (through, threw) hardships in life regardless of who they are.

Speak with your tutor

- "Give me fifteen sentences with gaps for commonly confused words (affect / effect, than / then, its / it's, who's / whose…). Check my answers and explain each mistake."
- "Dictate ten words from the table of commonly misspelled words, one at a time. I will type them. Then show me my errors and the problem areas."
- "Here is a paragraph I wrote: [paste]. Do not correct it. Tell me only how many confused words and spelling errors it has, so that I can find them myself."
- "Help me make mnemonic devices for separate, necessary and definite."
- "Look at my last essay: [paste]. Help me start a personal list of the words I confuse or misspell."

Read aloud

In each pair, the two words sound the same or almost the same. Say them clearly and think about the spelling.

1. I liked her new sweater. I knew she would wear that sweater today.
2. The principal held a conference for both parents and teachers.
3. The principle of human equality is an important foundation for all nations.
4. Hurricane winds af·FECT the amount of rainfall. The heavy rains will have an ef·FECT on the crop growth.
5. They ac·CEPT·ed our proposal for the conference.
6. She threw the football with perfect form. She walked through the door and out of his life.

Writing task

Write a paragraph of 150-200 words about a topic from PSYC 110, for example how sleep affects memory or the effects of stress on health. Use at least eight words from this lesson's lists correctly (for example affect, effect, than, then, its, it's, their, there, principle, led, past, lessen), and underline them. Then proofread the paragraph slowly, word by word, and add any word you were unsure of to your error log from Lesson 30.

Self-editing checklist:

- Did I read word by word, without skimming?
- its / it's, their / they're, your / you're, who's / whose: does each apostrophe replace missing letters?
- affect (verb) or effect (noun)? than (comparison) or then (time)?
- Did I write could / should / would have, never "of"?
- Did I follow the rules for final y and final e?
- Did I check words from the misspelled list in a dictionary?
- Did I run the spell checker, and then think about each suggestion before accepting it?

Paste your draft into the chat and ask your tutor for feedback. Then rewrite it.

Answer key

Exercise 1

1. two
2. quite
3. Your
4. than
5. then
6. loose
7. have
8. supposed; affect
9. sit; write
10. are; it's

Exercise 2

1. sets: sits
2. of passed: have passed
3. too snap: to snap
4. they're experience: their experience
5. an a bright light: and a bright light
6. to effect: to affect
7. but supposed: but suppose
8. its enough: it's enough
9. quit a different: quite a different
10. are country: our country
11. know longer: no longer

(The paragraph also has a typing error, "dministrators" for "administrators". It is not one of the eleven.)

Exercise 3

1. likly: likely (keep the final e before -ly)
2. disabilitys: disabilities (consonant + y: change y to i)
3. plagud: plagued (plague + d)
4. aleinated: alienated (from alien)
5. socializeing: socializing (drop the final e before -ing)
6. displaid: displayed (vowel + y: keep the y)
7. anthologeis: anthologies (consonant + y: change y to i)

8. noteably: notably (drop the final e before -able: notable)
9. storys: stories (consonant + y: change y to i)

Exercise 4

1. accross: across
2. beginings: beginnings
3. Immedietely: Immediately
4. Finalley: Finally
5. importent: important
6. ocasion: occasion
7. seperate: separate
8. opinien: opinion
9. intagration: integration
10. though: thought

(The name "Lenapi" is not one of the ten; this people's name is usually spelled Lenape.)

Exercise 5

1. principle
2. wear
3. led
4. which
5. piece
6. past
7. lessen
8. patience
9. sees
10. through

My notes